

STUDENT GUIDE

How to use the Project Planner

A short walkthrough of the tool that helps you plan your dissertation study and gives you an editable worksheet, links to the right guides that will help you get started, and the right people to contact.

What you'll walk away with

A Word document (.docx) you can keep editing, containing everything you enter: your design, the decisions you made, links to the guides you need, and who to email. Nothing is submitted anywhere — it's your working document.

In this guide

- How a session works, from start to worksheet
- The questions that need a little explaining
- Saving your progress, and coming back to it
- Getting help while you work
- A few things worth knowing before you start

How a session works

The planner asks one thing at a time. Most screens are a simple choice — tap the option that fits and you move on. A few screens ask you to fill in details about your study. There's no time limit and nothing is final until you download your worksheet, so it's fine to explore.

1 Tell it about your project

You start with the basics: your supervisor's email, a working title, your year of study, and a sentence or two on what your study is about.

2 Answer the branching questions

The planner narrows things down — quantitative or qualitative, what kind of study, how you're collecting data. Each answer shapes what it asks next, so you only see questions that apply to you.

3 Fill in your study design

One or two screens capture the detail: your variables, participants, sample size, analysis, dates and so on. Take your time here — vague answers get vague feedback later.

4 Get your plan

The final screen pulls it together: a recommended platform, any warnings to act on, your guide pack, and who to contact. From here you download your worksheet.

Changed your mind?

Every screen has a **Back** button, and it remembers what you'd typed — so stepping back to fix an earlier answer won't lose your later ones.

The **Step** counter in the top corner is just a rough sense of how far you've gone — because the questions branch, there's no fixed number of steps.

Questions that need a little explaining

Most screens are self-explanatory. These few are worth a quick word.

Choosing your study type

When you pick the kind of quantitative study you're doing, each option has a **What's this?** link. Tap it for a plain-language definition before you commit — handy if you're unsure whether your study is, say, a vignette or an eyewitness paradigm.

Your variables and design

Instead of typing your variables as a paragraph, you build them up: add each independent variable, give it its levels, and say how it's administered — **between-subjects** (each person is in one condition only) or **within-subjects** (each person does every condition). You don't need to know the name of your design: as you fill this in, the planner works it out and shows it back to you.

For example

Add **Sleep** (between-subjects, levels: deprived / rested) and **Test time** (within-subjects, levels: immediate / delayed), and the planner tells you: *2x2 mixed design — each participant is tested in one Sleep condition, at both Time points.*

For questionnaire and secondary-data studies the same tool asks instead for your predictors and outcomes — there's no between/within there, because those studies measure rather than manipulate.

Demographics

Tick every demographic you'll collect from participants — age, sex, and so on — and add any of your own the list doesn't cover. This one asks for at least one answer; if you genuinely aren't collecting demographics, choose **None**.

Standard questionnaires and stimuli

If you're using published scales, list them — and add a DOI or reference if you have one (optional). If your study uses stimuli or materials, say whether you have them yet; if you do, you can add a link and a description. It's worth noting your naming convention, file format and number of items here — it saves questions later.

Tick-all-that-apply vs pick-one

Where a question uses **checkboxes** you can choose more than one — participants and recruitment are like this, because real studies often draw on several groups or channels. Where it uses round buttons, pick the single best fit.

Saving your progress

Your answers are saved in your browser automatically as you go, so if you close the tab and come back, the planner offers to pick up where you left off. That save lives only on the device you're using.

Moving between devices, or keeping a backup

Once you're underway, a small toolbar appears near the top with three actions:

- **Save plan (JSON)** — downloads your whole plan as a file. Keep it as a backup, email it to your supervisor, or move it to another device.
- **Load plan** — re-opens a plan file, dropping you back exactly where you were. It only accepts files this planner made.
- **Clear saved data** — wipes the saved progress on this device and starts fresh. Save a JSON copy first if you might want it back.

JSON vs the worksheet — what's the difference?

The **JSON** file is a save file: it lets you (or the planner) reopen and keep editing your plan. The **worksheet** (.docx) is the finished output you hand to people. Use JSON to pause and resume; download the worksheet when you're ready to share.

Getting help while you work

At the very top of every screen there's a **Help & guides** panel. Tap it to expand it — it stays available wherever you are in the planner. Inside you'll find this guide and, where available, a short walkthrough video.

If a screen tells you to **contact your supervisor or the Psychology Technician**, that's not a dead end — it usually just means your plan needs a quick conversation. Carry on and finish your study details anyway, so you arrive at that conversation with something concrete. Both contacts, as live email links, end up on your worksheet.

A few things worth knowing

- **Your worksheet is editable.** It's an ordinary Word document — change anything, add notes, reformat it. There's even a blank section at the end for recording feedback from supervision meetings.
- **Nothing is submitted.** The planner doesn't send your answers anywhere. Downloading the worksheet or the JSON file is how you keep your work.
- **The guide links are real.** Your guide pack links straight to the relevant PDF guides — open them as you build your study.
- **Take the warnings seriously.** Anything under “Before you go any further” (working with under-18s, clinical or vulnerable groups, off-campus data collection, non-standard platforms) needs sorting before you collect data.